

CONTINUE YOUR STRUGGLE AND CEASE ALL STRUGGLE

Divine and joyful blessings, my beloved friends. Your tasks become more joyful, more fulfilling, more noticeably meaningful. For many of you this is so! Your inner paths bring this outer meaning to your life. As your community grows, the cleansing process must be an inexorable by-product, my beloved ones. As you cleanse yourselves inwardly and leave behind aspects of your personality that are not compatible with your newly awakening self, so must the entity pathwork do the same.

So we begin a new working season. Much expansion, excitement, fulfillment, and challenges await you. Even unavoidable hardship must ultimately become yet another tool for greater harmony and ecstasy. I wish to discuss this topic in the first lecture of your new working year.

In the great plan, also called the plan of salvation, the earth sphere is meant to gradually change into a more spiritual abode of unity, harmony and light. This cannot, of course, be an outer process that is "given" from outside. It can only come about through a transformation of consciousness in the earth's inhabitants. This transformation of consciousness, in turn, comes about as a result of laborious inner work -- the work of purification, self-confrontation, and of consequently finding new, deeper inner levels of reality hitherto disconnected from your conscious being. As the earth transforms, those individual consciousnesses that cannot and will not follow this process of growth and development, create a new abode similar to the conditions that have prevailed in this earth sphere and that are still prevailing now. These conditions begin to change already among a relatively small section of the earth's inhabitants. But as time goes on, the number will increase. Your specific path is a potent measure to bring this change about in a minimum amount of time. What might otherwise take many incarnations could be accomplished in one life time if the pathwork is truly followed to its maximum potential. Such transformations have already been witnessed among you and are being experienced by some of you as a strong sense of being reborn in this very lifetime.

I would like to discuss a particular aspect of this transformation of consciousness that has been mentioned many times before. But here I wish to emphasize very specifically what was previously discussed in more general ways. Mankind's greatest imprisonment, from which all fear and pain and suffering stem, is the duality in which the human mind is entangled. The mass mind then builds conditions and an environment that express this bent of consciousness. It is perhaps the most difficult aspect of man's evolutionary journey to penetrate the myth of this seeming reality -- the reality that the world is dualistic.

You seem to be put into an entirely objective world, all fixed and ready made. All conditions and natural laws seem to be unalterable givens that your state of consciousness has no influence on whatever. This false reality seems indeed the most "realistic" and sane acceptance of life. And the

problem is that to a certain degree this is indeed so. It is necessary to accept the world as you find it and deal with it on its own terms. For even after your own consciousness begins to change and transcend, the creation of mass mind still remains intact. In that transitional state, the individual lives in both realities. He fully accepts the created, dualistic reality, but recognizes simultaneously the new vision gradually evolving through the fog. This new vision you know about in your mind, but a few of you have occasionally begun to experience its reality. It is the absolute knowledge that there is only good, that there is eternal life, peace, joy, excitement, meaning, that there is nothing to fear, that there is no more pain. Part of this state of ultimate reality is also the knowledge that you create your world, your conditions, your environment; and that knowledge, rather than burdening you, gives you an immense sense of liberation and safety.

Not accepting the conditions of this dualistic world because of the vague knowledge of another state of mind that can be attained -- is an aberration. It expresses the childish desire for omnipotence in a cheap and easy way. It deludes itself that by an outer act of sheer will the developmental stages -- which sometimes must include temporary suffering -- can be avoided. Thus we have the apparent paradox of glimpsing ultimate reality in a false way leading to more unreality than not glimpsing it at all and fully accepting the conditions of this mass illusion. But when the limitations of these life conditions are being fully accepted and the personality deals with them honestly, maturely, productively, and constructively, then the inner evolutionary process continues organically, and the mind begins to encompass other visions that were invisible before. To deal with your limited reality in this way you must include a process of stringent self-work, such as this pathwork offers you.

Progress in this inner work brings about many changes. Changes of attitudes, changes of intentionalities, changes of feelings, changes of opinions, changes of world view and, last but not least, change of perceiving reality. A very simple and current example, on a very practical level, is what all of you continually experience on this path. You start out seeing a certain condition in your life in a very specific way. Let us say you are convinced that certain circumstances victimize you; that others are doing you a great wrong; that you have no recourse in changing these conditions, unless these others change their attitude and behavior toward you. Few are those who have entered this path where some such situation has not come up. In such a situation you start out with a very firmly held conviction. All aspects you can observe bear out this conviction. In fact, the more convinced you are, the more "proof" you will be able to collect as to how accurate your conviction is. This self-perpetuating vicious circle, this law that creates the vision according to your conviction, is the ensnarlment of the mind that is so hard to overcome.

Only as a result of much good will on your part to open your mind, to let go, at least temporarily, of your conviction will you begin to recognize new aspects that you could never see before. Perhaps you will see how you actively contributed to the situation that seemed to place all the responsibility onto the other person. You may recognize on yet deeper levels a definite intentionality to create a negative situation. This recognition will automatically shift the total picture. Not that it will place all the burden of guilt now on you and necessarily make a victim out of the previous villain, but you probably will see how you mutually affected each other.

This comprehension will open new vistas. You will soon come to recognize entirely unsensed aspects of yourself and the others involved -- both good and bad, favorable and unfavorable. But

underneath this duality of good versus bad one day you will find an ultimate, unchangeable level of truth in which all is good in a new, different, more alive, and very dynamic way.

Here I used a familiar example that demonstrates the process of extending man's vision to new realities. In this example, you find that the previous limitation seemed indeed plausible. You will find that it was inaccurate mostly because of its exclusivity; because you saw it out of context with other elements. And without cognizance of these other elements, the total picture is distorted. It was not false because your view is necessarily untrue in itself (although that exists too), but false because you leave out other essential elements that are necessary in order to glimpse the total picture. What I am trying to convey here is that many realities exist in regard to one and the same situation, condition, circumstance. By knowing this, you will beware of quick evaluations but will undertake the responsibility you carry to search, to grope, to make effort, to extend your vision.

The same process exists in regard to the world and its natural laws as you know them. Your world view is based on a very incomplete vision that allows only limited areas of your perception to filter into your consciousness. You see what appears most obvious on an entirely superficial level. But as you grow personally, as your perception of reality of your personal circumstances widens, so does your perception of creation begin to alter, to widen, and deepen. You glimpse connections you have never seen before and that are now as obvious as the limited reality you perceived before.

The dualistic world view seems an incontrovertible fact. Not to see your world in terms of opposites, of duality, appears the crassest form of delusion. And it is true indeed that on the level of appearance, duality is a fact. Life seems to die. Evil always lurks somewhere in the shadows no matter how much good also exists. Light opposes darkness. Night opposes day. Where there is health there also exists sickness. Yet, another reality awaits to be recognized underneath this level of opposites. Since living within the level of duality (opposites) brings pain and strain, it is the soul's greatest longing to find this deeper level of truth. This longing, as I often said, exists regardless of whether or not a person is conscious of it. It fills the heart precisely because it is within the scheme of an individual's potential to awaken into this new level at some point of his or her evolutionary journey.

I have talked about this before, and the reason I mention it now is because I wish to show the way more precisely how to attain this new level of perception and of being. It must be clearly understood that the goal cannot be willed by the outer will alone. It cannot come about as a result of philosophical speculation or theoretical knowledge or even as a result of specific exercises, methods, or disciplines. The change of consciousness happens entirely due to an intensely personal purification process that, to begin with, deals always with the most mundane matters of your practical life, with your attitudes toward these matters and your general surroundings. Practical everyday matters are always an expression of inner, subtle, and finally spiritual attitudes. To skip them and consider them irrelevant only leads to further separation, duality (spirituality versus practical life). Therefore, ultimately this leads to a delusory spirituality that is not grounded in the now. This is why you find this path so intensely practical and utterly compatible with your life of matter, your daily activity, and your goals. The path is not only compatible with these, but it is also an expression of the most subtle spiritual (or anti-spiritual) attitudes.

Let us now attempt to be a little more specific about attaining the new consciousness in which creation is no longer perceived in terms of duality. Perhaps we should begin by pointing out how

painful and fearful duality really is. For this is often so much taken for granted that you cannot even perceive the pain and fear. You do not know anything else. This is all there is, so how could you even begin to chafe under it? It is a similar dynamic to a child's hardly feeling his painful conditions simply because he does not know that other conditions might exist. In order to change existing conditions, one must feel them as so desirable that the effort is well worth taking. But one must also know that they can be changed, that other possibilities indeed exist.

Most human beings do not know that duality is painful, nor how painful it really is. Nor do they know that another way of living exists, another view of perception exists that totally eliminates this pain. Living trapped in the limited world of duality, there is always the fear of the undesirable -- the straining away from it and straining toward the desirable. This very straining is extremely painful and anxiety producing. But this strain becomes conscious only at a point on your path after a great deal of crude purification work has been accomplished. If this specific strain is being dealt with before such crude purification work -- such as you are involved with now -- important steps are being skipped, and the process cannot take place in an organic, grounded way. So what I shall discuss now may not necessarily be appropriate for a number of my friends at this time, but I believe it will help all of you to comprehend some of these aspects now, even before you are ready on your personal path to really emphasize this new phase. It may also facilitate your present phase if you can connect with some of my words; and it may help you to deepen some of your present understanding of yourself in regard to simple purification work you have been doing all along.

Obviously we are talking here about different states of mind. If the dualistic state of mind becomes more firmly entrenched in the painful, fearful dualism through straining from the undesirable alternative, then it must figure that the straining must be relinquished. Yet, how can I say to you, do not wish for happiness as opposed to suffering; life as opposed to death; health as opposed to illness, and so on? You would hardly be human if you would not deeply desire happiness, life, health.

But there is a state of mind in which the straining relaxes, in which the undesirable can be dealt with in an almost similar spirit and attitude as the desirable. This may appear very strange to you now, but I truly say to you, my beloved friends, this is indeed so. Perhaps the first step in this particular scale is to pay attention to the by-products in your feelings, thoughts, attitudes as you experience either a desirable or an undesirable state. If the desirable occurs, you are probably most likely to feel faith in the Lord, to experience His reality; you can connect with the Christ within; you can be joyful in the knowledge that all is well in this world. (I now address myself to individuals who do believe in and can occasionally experience spiritual reality beyond this earth reality, and not people who have never yet experienced this level of being). But it is infinitely more difficult to maintain the same faith, the same knowing, when the undesirable experiences occur. The feelings immediately fluctuate like the needle in a compass. Just begin to observe your moods. When are doubts coming up? What brings on these doubts? Is it not always in some way connected with whether or not the desirable goal occurs?

The Christed person does not experience these fluctuations. The outer experience in no way influences which level of reality he is connected with. It is indeed true that such a person reacts to pain in no way differently than he reacts to pleasure. In that way they become indeed one and the same. To put it differently, duality is being transcended.

This kind of detachment is strongly fostered by Eastern religions, as well as by the Western mystics. It explains why these disciplines negate worldly fulfillment and consider them an antithesis to the goal of spiritual self-realization. It explains all the disciplines of asceticism and deliberately imposed suffering. Yet, valuable as these approaches may be to a degree, does not the deliberate negation of the desirable lead to a similar state of duality, only approached from the other end? He who denies the undesirable is not much different from him who denies the desirable, who does not permit himself to rejoice in it!

Also there seems to exist another kind of contradiction that has led to many confusions in the human mind and in the spiritual aspirants. Is it not also claimed by spiritual teachers and seers that God's will is your happiness, your human fulfillment, your health, your well being, your healing when you are ill, your productivity and success in life? So how then can you negate this life here and now that the Creator has given you? Does it seem right to abdicate all material existence and deny its desirable aspects because you know that there exists a yet deeper, much more permanent state of mind in which you can experience life and fulfillment without the breaks that are part and parcel of the dualistic state of mind?

All these questions seem fraught with conflict and contradiction -- at least on this level of reality. In a deeper sense there are no contradictions at all. It is utterly possible to rejoice in worldly fulfillments as expressions of inner states, while no longer straining toward one state and away from another. This latter attitude can exist only when you deeply know that ultimately there is the reality of God; there is life eternal; and there is fulfillment and well being in every possible way. Because you have attained a state without straining, you glimpse and finally experience this other reality. It is equally true to state that you can relinquish the straining because you glimpse this state. It must be approached from both ends.

It would be virtually impossible to start out with an attempt to feel the same way about two opposites. You could not possibly make yourself react the same way to pleasure as to pain. It is a natural movement of the human manifestation to strain toward pleasure and away from pain. Even the often encountered fear of and denial of pleasure is essentially nothing but another version of fear and denial of pain. So how then is one to start in this particular direction, you may well ask. As long as the strain between two opposites of a duality exists, you must live in fear, in inner tension; and you cannot realize your ultimate state of unity in which there is no death and no pain.

The way to go about it at first is to stand back and truly observe your reactions to pain and pleasure, to life and death. These reactions contain a great deal of material that you need to become quite clear about but that you generally ignore. These reactions have become so much second nature to you that you cannot see the forest for the trees. Fear and desire are only the most common denominators that designate a host of other feelings and attitudes. In your fear of death and of pain and in your movement to strain away from them, there is usually contained a great deal of anger, bitterness, and resentments. It is not toward a specific person or deity. It is a more general, diffuse, but nevertheless quite distinct, state of mind. Many times these feelings of bitterness and anger become enmeshed into the system that they themselves turn into the pain that is so rejected. In other words, what started out as a small pain manifestation and what might dissolve smoothly and relatively soon, becomes more firmly entrenched and aggravated. It is, once again, not so much these anger feelings themselves as their suppression and repression. The fact that you are unaware of them and that they can therefore exist underground has the damaging effect.

You therefore need to make these reactions very clear and conscious. This is in a certain way more difficult than with specifically directed anger feelings toward specific individuals and specific events. The latter may contradict your idealized self-image, your moral standards, your overall personality, but the former anger is so irrational and unreasonable seeming that the ordinary person fears insanity if he riles against what life is known to be. How can you "reasonably" resent the existence of death? How can you be angry about it? How can you even be angry that you, like all other humans, fall occasionally ill and suffer pains? Yet there exists a rage toward life and creation in all human souls before realization of the unitive, deathless, painless state has been attained. The feeling is, if it were articulated: how can life (God) be so cruel as to impose an inevitable event at the end of one's existence that is unfathomable, that is totally unknown, that is deeply threatening because it may be the end of one's existing, of one's being. No matter how certain individuals who have to come to embrace atheism claim to have accepted to no longer exist, in this very "acceptance" lies the ultimate of rage. Atheism itself is a manifestation of extreme bitterness against a creation that seems so utterly senseless and arbitrary that no recourse exists. Atheism is the movement that cuts off all sensibilities and sensitivities which might open up the perception of deeper and different realities.

There can never be a genuine "acceptance" of ending one's being. Such false acceptance is always either an angry bitter resignation or despair with life and its pains. At the same time, accepting eternal life can also come from identical reasons of fear. So you need to go through your inner fear and your previously unconscious anger, bitterness, or rage at life for imposing death and pain on you, for putting you in a position in which you find yourself helpless against these common human experiences. As you become aware of these feelings and accept their apparent unreasonableness and childishness, you will then be able to make new connections. You will see how the unrecognized feelings have channeled themselves, in what particular way they have found expression. And since this kind of deflection can never lead to clarity and truth, to harmony and unity, the deflection leads you further away from the fulfillment of your soul's longing -- namely the real inner knowing of the unitive state. Thus, the less aware you are of what you feel about these very general existential matters of life, the more irrational these feelings will become. The less you can permit yourself to face them (or so you believe), the more deflected they will be, and the deeper you become ensnared in the dualistic state with all its painful strains and anxieties. The denied fear creates more fear. The denied longing and desire create anxiety, not peace. Only the courage to go through these feelings will purify them as the gold emerges in the hands of the alchemist. Both the fear and the desire will become the driving force, in a most positive sense, to find your longing, to find that in this longing exists a kernel of true knowing that it can find fulfillment.

From this stage slowly comes and with many interruptions at first, a state in which you want life, not because you fear death, but because you know that there is no death. You know that leaving the body brings a better life. These words have often been spoken, but they are rarely experienced as inner truth. To do so, a specific approach on your path, such as I outline here, must be pursued. There is a vast difference between hanging on to life because you fear annihilation of all you are, of who you have become, and between affirming life because you cherish the task your life on earth means. You rejoice in bringing parts of the greater, real life into this dualistic plane and to thus spiritualize the matter you temporarily inhabit.

The same applies to pain and painful experiences. If pain is suspected as the ultimate reality, there must be a lot of anger connected with experiencing it. By the same token, if pain is assumed to only come to life's stepchildren, this, too, must create bitterness and rage. Often, these feelings

augment the pain, extend it until the pain can become the medicine it is meant to be. That is, you can use it as the guidepost for these other feelings so as to ferret them out and become acutely conscious of them. If pain is defended against, even on the deepest possible psychic level, a tightening comes into existence that prevents healing. Healing requires a deep and more than physical relaxation of the entire human system in order to connect with the ever present divine healing currents that penetrate all that is. A system that is defended against anything -- be it common human experience such as pain, suffering, and death, be it one's own feelings of rage and bitterness about what seems insane to resist and react against -- is in a state of tension and therefore unable to heal itself.

This state of deep relaxation of body, mind, and the feeling self brings about the attitude I described at the beginning of this lecture, a state that may seem impossible ever to attain. This kind of equanimity does not express a disregard for earthly pleasure and life in the body. But it no longer fears their absence. This state does not rush into death and pain, but feels an inner peace because the glimpses of reality follow more quickly in succession. This is so because the person has begun to closely observe reactions to the fears and desires in regard to life and death, pleasure and pain. And as these observations become more honest, more clearly defined, more detached, less involved (that which is being observed is not being confused with who the person is as a whole), a new state of mind, the unitive state of mind, is automatically and inexorably, if ever so slowly, ushered in.

So, my beloved friends, try to think about all this and begin a new outlook and direction, wherever possible, on your individual paths. It will facilitate much and it will ready you for the great fusion that must ultimately come about for each created being, a fusion that no longer knows the pain and separateness of the dualistic state of mind.

As you search in this direction given you here, you will also find, once again, a "reverse unity" which, in its own way, will help you to understand the nature of your mind steeped in dualistic confusions. Every so often you believe you fear one end of the spectrum and strive and desire for the opposite end of it. But as you confront your real feelings, as opposed to your illusion about yourself, you find that you fear the apparently desired end (at least on one important level of intentionality) perhaps every bit as much as that which you consciously fear. So you realize the "unity" of fear. Life is feared as much as death; pain as much as pleasure; failure as much as success. Out of this "reverse unity" a real unity can grow, when you comprehend the nature of the fear at both ends of the spectrum. As you get in touch with both fears, you have inadvertently attained a certain measure of equanimity. The strain automatically relaxes and you are then confronted with the issue of faith. There comes the point on your path when it is a question of just that. Do you wish to be open to your surrounding universe and look at it from the point of view of justifying faith? Do you only see, perhaps wish to see in anger and bitterness, the out-of-context fragments of life that seem to imply cruelty and meaninglessness? This question may occupy you over years of serious and beautiful struggle, the most noble struggle in the human soul. But the time must come when inner, deeply experienced answers will come.

Negation of truth, beauty, love, and the meaning of creation always stems from bitterness, fear, and anger. This can only open more vistas that justify this negation and hide the vistas that harbor the most realistically grounded affirmation of all opposites: of life and death, pleasure and pain, light and darkness.

When you can maintain this vision, even while in pain; when you can know that God does it right, even while you face the great unknown (however near or far it may be), your mind will be stilled. It will have ceased the struggle that attempts to "find out" of the pain of duality but in fact only draws the net tighter by the very nature of the struggle itself. The tense movement away from one and toward another "goal" will cease, and the underlying unity of all life will be experienced.

This ceasing of a particular level and type of struggle must not be confused with apathy, passivity, lack of initiative, and so on. You know very well how important your committed active effort is, how noble your struggle, as I point out again and again. Struggle on one level, in a certain way, is necessary; it is the inevitable prerequisite for plowing through the mazes of the mind. Struggle on another level, in another way, is the movement that ripples the water and prevents the peace that flows from the Most Holy.

Struggle is another of the dualities that exist in your world. Many spiritual movements totally negate its necessity and advocate detachment, not only from worldly matters, but from all striving. They are completely correct in that they know what I attempt to make you see here. They think of that level where fear and desire annihilate unity and trap the mind into deeper illusions of the world. But they do not connect with that level of the personality that needs to strive and struggle. They ignore that there exists a healthy and constructive struggle. The pitfall of this one-sidedness is that, through its very one-sidedness, it leads, from a subtle direction, again into more duality and thus perverts the peace that may occasionally be experienced at first, into a passive standstill.

Then you have those spiritual approaches which advocate the struggle and the work. They, too, are correct. They know the necessity for it and help the followers to summon the energies and stamina. But they often ignore that other level where struggle defeats the purpose and only ripples the waters more stormily.

To you, my friends, I bring the truth of both ends of this particular human split. Continue your struggle, and cease all struggle. Grope for where struggle must continue and where it must cease. And you will experience at some time the incomparable peace of no longer fearing what you do not want and no longer reaching anxiously and strenuously for what you want, because you will know that all that could ever be desirable is right here, attainable right now, ever present at the tips of your fingers, and all that you fear and strain away from is nothing but illusion, even though you may be in the midst of experiencing it. So you will truly become still and know God. You will know God in all that is, in the best and worst, in what you want and what you do not want. Both are what your deeper self knows is intensely desirable, much better than what you think you want and not at all what you fear.

This is but a vague outline for your further path, perhaps a whiff that can be gleaned now. Even that vague gleaning will prepare you better for your further glorious path, my blessed, beloved friends. You all live and move and have your being in the Christ consciousness, in the Christ principle!

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